Made Across America

Where work happens and who connects it

Vince Jiang · v1.1 · 5 November 2026

Argument

The geography of American manufacturing is better understood by distinguishing where work occurred from who controlled its connections. Across six cases, ownership, exchange, contracts and coercive labor relations crossed production locations in different ways. Distance alone does not describe a progression from local work to globalization.

Why these objects

A Saugus nail (c.1650), Lowell cloth (1835), Armour canned meat (1893–1901), Ford Model A (1928), RCA television (1965) and the original iPhone (2007) make different relationships visible. Colonial iron production depended on Atlantic investment; northern cloth production depended on enslaved cotton labor. Later cases distinguish a retail market from an unknown factory, integration from self-sufficiency, company plants from outside sales, and an American brand from domestic assembly.

How the evidence is used

The project compares selected cases rather than measuring a national trend. An advertisement establishes an offer for sale, not a shipment; a company report establishes a reported plan or arrangement, not its completion. The source registers distinguish original records, historical interpretation, catalog entries and unresolved questions. Cowie's account of labor control challenges a technical-capacity explanation of RCA's geography. The references below identify a concise route through the evidence; the extended dossier supplies the complete bibliography and reading limits.

Course and creative method

The cases develop Lectures 2–6 on colonial commerce, sectional divisions, railways and industrial capital, automobiles, and postwar geography. Lecture 1's questions about maps and Lecture 7's close-reading method shape the presentation. Selecting a manufacturing task highlights an object's components and regional roles; a relationship card asks who connected that work. Generated imagery explains structure, while sources establish historical claims. The maps retain unknown links rather than drawing invented shipment routes.

References in use

Selected reading route · complete register in the extended dossier

01 Regan, J., & White, C. (n.d.). “Hammersmith through the historical texts.” In Saugus iron works (ch.2, pp.27–28,32). National Park Service.
Historical interpretation: colonial privileges, investment and failure.

02 National Park Service. (2020, September 22). Southern ties & northern gospels.
Historical interpretation: cotton, slavery and Lowell clothing sales; linked 1835 table read separately.

03 J. & I. Blum. (1893, January 28). Retail advertisement naming Armour Corned Beef. Vacaville Reporter, p.3.
Primary record: distant retail presence; factory and shipment origin remain unknown.

04 Ford Motor Company, Photographic Department. (1928, February 8). Ford Model A assembly line, Rouge Plant [Photograph]. The Henry Ford.
Primary image with museum description: the dated assembly anchor, not every input’s provenance.

05 Broadcasting. (1965, June 21). All-color TV only one year away? pp.27–29.
Contemporary reporting: RCA plant roles, announced spending and tube forecasts.

06 Cowie, J. (n.d.). Introduction. Capital moves: RCA’s seventy-year quest for cheap labor, pp.1–9 consulted. The New Press.
Secondary interpretation: labor control and relocation. Original work 1999; excerpt’s reprint date unconfirmed.

07 Apple Inc. (2007). Form 10-K, fiscal year ended September 29, 2007, pp.12,16.
Corporate disclosure: China assembly, concentrated outsourcing and reduced direct control.

Contribution and assistance

Vince Jiang set the research question, object-led scope and exhibition design priorities, and reports reading all earlier webpage text and revising portions. ChatGPT/Codex assisted with searches, research organization, drafting, editing, implementation and image generation; Claude Code reviewed frozen v1. v1.1 reflects checked revisions, not a second Claude approval. The extended dossier records functions by output. The student reports prior instructor approval for AI use and is preparing the final-project meeting; the written permission record and scope have not been supplied.

Extended research dossier ↗ · Exact lecture references ↗